
Comments for the Author(s)

This manuscript addresses a genuinely important policy question regarding Chile's perceived security crisis. The paper tests if the crisis is attributable to a volumetric increase in violent crime or a compositional shift using a well-constructed panel dataset covering 16 regions over 156 months. The central finding, that the ratio of violent to non-violent property crimes has risen to a historical peak driven primarily by the structural decline of non-violent offenses rather than by absolute growth of violent ones, is interesting. Though, the ratio measure of comparing violent to non-violent offense types reflects more of a descriptive scope than a causal process. Several concerns are outlined below including the concept and measurement of crime composition and dependent variable terminology, limitations in theoretical integration, and modeling decisions specific to the research questions sequenced.

Revisions

The authors should consider removing the word “property” from the title as it does not reflect field consensus on property crime types as the study considers “robbery.” Drop property – and maybe violent – and consider the use of robbery. Or defend these terminological distinctions more clearly in the write-up as the in-text description of roadblock theft and snatching seems to align more with the field definitions of robbery than property crime.

The abstract is overly detailed in terms of results and statistics. It should be re-written to better reflect study contributions and takeaways. The current read of it is too jargon centric and dense, both analytically (methods used) and statistically (results generated).

The research question is a little clunky in present form and wording. It functionally asks has violent crime increased in absolute terms or in perceptual terms? I think rewriting to simply reflect this would be a more streamlined inquiry.

I expected the literature review to at least include some discussion or a short section on the elements of a crisis – maybe moral panic work from applied sociology or more recent discourse on social uprisings and crime. There seems to be a theoretical angle in play that needs contextualized, even in a quant-centric journal like JQC. Some of this content is in there, but at present the literature review is a bit jumbled and bouncy.

The third hypothesis is a little confusing. Couldn't regional heterogeneity co-exist with the other hypotheses sequenced? It does not seem conceptually exclusive in occurrence and therefore seems separate and distinct from the first order research question tested in H1 and H2.

The paper estimates three separate Poisson models and then interprets the difference in their trajectories as evidence of compositional shift. This approach introduces the problem of model-to-model comparability. The three models share the same specification, but any systematic difference in overdispersion, unobserved heterogeneity structure, or time-series dynamics across

crime types means that coefficient differences across equations cannot straightforwardly be interpreted as measuring a single compositional process. This convolutes the compositional metric.

In some places, "compositional change" means the ratio of violent to non-violent robberies is rising (a within-category-set proportional shift). In others, it refers to qualitative changes in the nature of individual crime events, for example, the emergence of encerronas and portonazos or the growth of victim retention offenses. These are related but distinct phenomena. The paper treats these as complementary evidence of the same underlying process, but they operate through different mechanisms and have different policy implications. The conceptual framework in Section 2 would benefit from explicitly distinguishing (a) between-category compositional shifts (the main focus), (b) within-category qualitative changes, and (c) the substitution toward digital fraud (discussed in Section 6 but not integrated into the compositional framework).

The paper never formally tests compositional change as such. The main inferential models estimate the rate of each crime type separately, and compositional inference is drawn by comparing coefficients across three independently estimated equations. This approach conflates the question "is violent crime declining?" with the question "is crime becoming more violent in composition?" These are related but distinct questions: the composition ratio can rise even if both numerator and denominator are declining, as long as they decline at different rates, and distinguishing this from a scenario in which violent crime is genuinely stable while non-violent crime collapses requires a within-model test of the ratio, not a cross-equation comparison of levels. The Bai-Perron analysis of the ratio provides descriptive evidence of compositional change, but the authors explicitly disclaim its inferential status ("its function is exclusively descriptive").

Relatedly, the digital fraud section is introduced too late and feels peripheral to the other analyses. If physical non-violent crime is declining partly because theft is shifting to digital channels, which reflects a modal substitution rather than genuine crime suppression, then the paper's central conclusion (that the rising ratio of violent to non-violent crime reflects compositional change rather than a security crisis) may itself be overstated. The authors may need to tend to this result artifact with more care.

The results section is robust in analysis and presentation, with many tables and figures. It is hard to adequately sift through and the overarching "answer" to the research question is not readily apparent. Some of the analyses seem to fit more within the methodology setup while others are more apt to answering the stated research question. The authors could do work here to streamline this.

Again, the framing of the discussion is largely plagued by the selected terminology of things like "non-violent robbery." This does not reflect general field consensus and definitional alignment.